FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Gauging the public mood is a fascinating task in vexed times like these. From geopolitics to national politics and the economy, every realm of India's collective life seems to be colliding into the next. Each is now coated with a sense of crisis that was not present in our last Mood of the Nation poll in February. Since then, we have had a four-day war with Pakistan, a stunning diplomatic reversal that sees a 50 per cent US tariff rate kicking in this week and a supercharged Opposition campaign against electoral rolls that's heating up the political landscape. In short, the towering persona of Narendra Modi is being sternly tested. To his credit, the prime minister seems to gather strength each time he is pressed by adversity.

To use a cricketing analogy, Modi is not merely a flat-track blaster who performs only when the pitch is easy. Over 11 years as prime minister, he has shown he can bat through difficult spells and still control the scoreboard. The numbers reflect this resilience. This time, an impressive 58 per cent deem Modi's performance as prime minister 'good' to 'outstanding', a slight dip of 3.84 per cent percentage points from February. He also nets a 51.5 per cent endorsement as the leader best suited to be the next PM. The ratings for Rahul Gandhi, his prime challenger, remain at 24.7 per cent. These findings reiterate that the prime minister still enjoys substantial public trust and is seen as the most capable to navigate India through turbulent times.

▲ February 24, 2025

The ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA) has reason to be reassured. If the Lok Sabha election were to be held now, the MOTN accords it 324 seats. This is 19 seats down from February, but 52 more than the simple majority mark and way more secure than the 293 it won in the summer of 2024. Its projected 46.7 per cent vote share, too, marks a good 4 percentage point rise over that election. Likewise, 52.4 per cent say they are 'satisfied' or 'very satisfied' with the NDA performance. Since that too marks a dip of 10 percentage points from February, we could describe it overall as 'comfortable, but with caveats'. This applies equally to the BJP. Its individual vote share stays at 40.6 per cent, but its seat tally is down from 281 in February to 260 now. That's short of a simple majority by 12 seats, yet an improvement on its 2024 Lok Sabha tally of 240.

There is food for thought here. The euphoria from the election victories of Haryana and Maharashtra last year has waned for the BJP. The Opposition has gained some ground, though still short of critical mass. The Congress is the main beneficiary, with 47 per cent rating its performance as an Opposition party 'outstanding' or 'good'. This was only 40 per cent in February. The X-factor is Rahul Gandhi, who emerges as the most preferred choice to lead the Opposition alliance, clocking 28.2 per cent. With other anti-BJP leaders appearing comfortable ceding space to him, at least for now, he has taken his charge of 'vote *chori*' to new levels of audibility and visibility, from Parliament to the dusty tracks of Bihar. Almost a third of our respondents seem inclined to believe him. It seems Rahul Gandhi fares better when he attacks the BJP on policy issues than when he makes personal criticisms, especially of PM Modi. Away from the battlefield of narratives, a gap in the strength of organisational machinery is what substantially separates the two sides now.

The economy is where more grey tones emerge. Those who approve of Modi government's handling has dipped by 4.5 percentage points since February to 47.8 per cent, while those who disapprove has increased to 30 per cent. Pessimism is rising: 55 per cent believe the economy will stagnate or worsen over the next six months. Half of all respondents say becoming the fourth largest economy is just a symbolic achievement with little benefit for common people, rather than a meaningful milestone that tracks real progress. Worryingly, 33.7 per cent say their financial situation has worsened since Modi took office, up from 30.9 per cent in February. The perception that India's growth is favouring big business persists: 55.8 per cent now feel the Modi government exclusively favours big business. A high 46.2 per cent also feel the government has not adequately supported small businesses and startups.

There are other disquieting signs in the socio-political space that the Modi dispensation would do well to pay heed to. There are disturbingly high numbers for those who believe India's democracy is under threat. Fewer seem convinced by Modi's anti-corruption rhetoric or political use of central investigating agencies. Increasingly, governors are seen as partisan actors. Among all the perceptual markers, the Modi government's economic ratings are the most material. These are clear signs of unhappiness, which the Trump's tariff shocker will now exacerbate. Yet, even as these concerns mount, the perception of Modi's leadership remains intact. That contrast is striking. It gives him a rare political advantage. The political arithmetic is in his favour. Considering the economic and geopolitical challenges the country is facing at the moment, this is the most opportune time to push through his next generation of reforms which the country sorely needs. As recent history has shown, India acts best when confronted with a crisis.

(Aroon Purie)